

Hypervigilance After Birth — Action Checklist

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RECOGNIZE YOUR EXPERIENCE

- ☐ **Take the 8-Question Self-Assessment:** Answer yes or no to all eight questions about alertness, startle responses, sleep, checking, tension, racing thoughts, and waiting for something to go wrong, and count how many times you answered yes to determine if you're experiencing hypervigilance.
- ☐ **Understand This Is a Mammalian Response:** Accept that your hypervigilance is your body running ancient survival programming designed to protect a vulnerable infant from predators, not a sign that you're broken or weak.
- ☐ **Identify the Sleep Deprivation Loop:** Recognize that hypervigilance prevents sleep, which lowers your anxiety threshold, which increases hypervigilance, creating a cycle that requires active intervention to break.
- ☐ **Distinguish Hypervigilance from Normal Worry:** Notice that normal new parent worry focuses on specific concerns like feeding or rashes, while hypervigilance is a body-wide threat-assessment state with no off switch.

PRACTICE GROUNDING DAILY

- ☐ **Perform the 5-4-3-2-1 Sensory Exercise:** Look around and name 5 things you can see, 4 things you can physically feel, 3 things you can hear, 2 things you can smell, and 1 thing you can taste to interrupt an adrenaline spike and anchor yourself in present-moment safety.
- ☐ **Practice Box Breathing:** Inhale for 4 counts, hold for 4 counts, exhale for 4 counts, and hold for 4 counts, making your exhale longer than your inhale to activate the parasympathetic nervous system and trigger your body's natural relaxation response.
- ☐ **Apply Cold Water to Your Wrists:** Splash cold water on your wrists or hold an ice cube there for 30 seconds to trigger the mammalian dive reflex, which causes your heart rate to drop and interrupts the fight-or-flight state within seconds.
- ☐ **Schedule Preventive Grounding Check-Ins:** Set a timer every 2 to 3 hours during the day to perform one grounding exercise, even when you don't feel like you need it, because prevention is significantly easier than trying to interrupt a full adrenaline spike.

INTERRUPT THE THREAT LOOP

- ☐ **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open hypervigilance-after-birth_v1.md and review the relevant section.

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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.